

Cinematic Poker

Sit down at a table that feels like a place. Six characters who bluff, tilt, talk and remember how you play. Offline, single-player — and we will never sell you chips.

The plan: own the niche of single players on **mobile and tablet** who want RDR2-style NPC poker as its own game, monetise with one-time content unlocks only (no real money, no card details, no ads), deploy \$1,000 as ten measured experiments — and expand to other platforms only where the profit comparison says it pays.

\$1,000

Paid launch budget,
deployed as gated
experiments

\$5.9k

Base-case 12-month profit,
mobile + tablet core

\$11.4k

Base case with the optional
M4 Steam expansion

0

Chips sold · ads shown ·
card numbers touched

37k

Base-case year-one installs
(~28% tablets → ~37% of
revenue)

M1

Base-case breakeven month

"RDR2 poker, as its own game" — a viable wedge

RDR2's saloon poker is one of gaming's most beloved minigames — not because the poker is deep (it isn't), but because of **diegetic immersion**: a table in a place, with characters who talk, react and exist. Players repeatedly ask for this as a standalone product. Nobody has shipped it — and nobody has shipped it **where this player actually has time to play: on their phone and tablet**.

Why the demand is real

Scale

RDR2 sold 65M+ copies. A sliver who loved the poker specifically outnumbers most indie audiences.

Explicit, repeated asks

r/reddeadredemption recurrently asks "what scratches the RDR2 poker itch?" — every answer today is unsatisfying. An unanswered recurring question in a large community is the cheapest marketing signal that exists.

Proven, then abandoned

Poker Night at the Inventory validated character-driven single-player poker, earned a sequel, then was delisted. A decade of demand, zero supply — never on mobile or tablet.

Risks & mitigations

IP Trademark exposure

"Red Dead" never appears in anything we control — product, store metadata, our ad copy. Comparisons live only in creator / community / press speech (legal editorial use). The public name stays **Cinematic Poker**.

EXPECTATIONS AAA fidelity gap

Build-in-public devlogs set honest expectations; we sell ambience, characters and tells — never graphics parity.

PRODUCT Deliver the fantasy at minute one

The Western 1860s saloon is promoted to **free flagship environment**. With environments-as-data this is a content re-ordering, not an engineering change.

Verdict: viable — the strongest available wedge. It unifies what the product already is (cinematic places, characters with tells and memory, offline single-player) under one instantly-understood promise, and it stacks with the anti-chip-casino counter-position: those apps are exactly what this player is fleeing.

Competitive landscape & our edge

COMPETITOR	MODEL	WEAKNESS WE EXPLOIT
Zynga Poker · WSOP · PokerStars Play	F2P chip casino, online	Chip sales, ads, connection required, zero table personality — loudly resented in their own reviews
Governor of Poker 3	F2P chip casino, campaign veneer	Abandoned the beloved paid single-player formula of GoP 1–2
Governor of Poker 1–2	Paid single-player	10+ years old, dated presentation, simplistic AI, no tells or coaching
Poker Night at the Inventory 1–2	Premium character poker (PC)	Delisted — validated demand, zero supply, never on mobile or tablet
Prominence Poker	F2P console/PC, online	Not mobile, not offline, not single-player-first
RDR2 itself	AAA; poker is a minigame	100GB install, no quick hand on the bus; shallow poker AI — ours is the actual product

Five defensible edges (features, not claims)

1 · Opponents with character

12-parameter AI personalities, tilt model, opponent memory (VPIP / PFR / 3-bet), probabilistic tells with false tells. Nobody on mobile has this.

2 · Offline-first

Flights, commutes, no account, no server — and "offline poker" is a high-intent, low-competition search cluster.

3 · Ethical monetisation

We sell *places*, never chips. A moral stance that doubles as the marketing hook.

4 · "Improve My Game" coaching

Hand-history review makes the game a poker trainer — a second audience and keyword cluster no competitor can copy.

5 · The web demo

A shareable, zero-install playable link running the identical engine. Every post, comment and email ends in "play it right now."

Counter-positioning is the only marketing strategy that works on \$1,000 — and we counter the entire category at once.

How we get paid — no real money, no card details

The constraint, honoured by design: in-game chips are score — they can never be bought, sold or cashed out, keeping us outside gambling licensing entirely (stores' "simulated gambling" category, 12+/Teen rating). All purchases are **one-time content unlocks via Apple / Google IAP**: the platforms process 100% of payments, and the app collects no account, no personal data, no payment data.

On iOS that earns the rare **"Data Not Collected"** privacy label — a genuine differentiator in a category famous for data harvesting. Put it in the screenshots.

Never: loot boxes, gacha, randomised monetisation, ads, subscriptions. Every purchase is a known thing at a known price.

Tablet is the premium slice

Card and board games over-index on iPad; sessions run longer and tablet players convert at ~1.5× the phone rate — ~28% of installs producing ~37% of revenue. So: dedicated iPad screenshots and preview video (tablet ASO is its own surface), and tells art-directed to read beautifully at tablet size.

ITEM	PRICE
Base game — Western Saloon flagship, full engine, 5 NPCs, coaching, Mates' Kitchen second table	Free
Environment packs — a new place <i>and</i> a new NPC cast with new tells & dialogue (Kalgoorlie, Chicago 1926, Vegas, Disco 1978, Tokyo, Spaceport...); visitable before buying	\$3.99– 4.99
Everything Edition — all current and future environments; priced so two packs ≈ bundle	\$14.99 → \$19.99
Supporter tip — "buy the dealer a whisky"	\$2.99
Steam / desktop premium — expansion option, ships M4 only if the mobile base case holds (profit comparison, \$07)	\$9.99

2–4%

of installs
become
payers

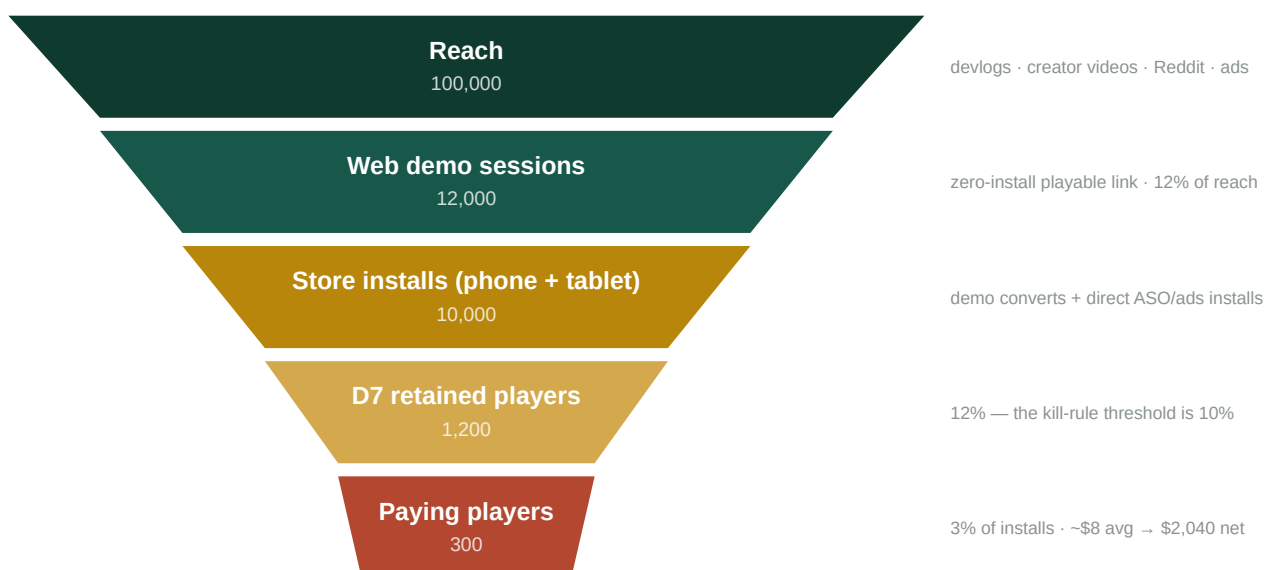
~\$8

avg revenue
per payer
(mobile)

85%

net kept —
store small-
business tier

The acquisition funnel — base case, launch quarter (illustrative)



Budget allocation — ten experiments, hard kill rules

LINE	\$	KILL / SUCCESS GATE
Creator seeding — 20–25 poker + RDR2-adjacent micro-creators (5k–100k); \$25–50 paid for the 6–8 best fits; A/B the two framings	350	≥4 videos live in launch week; track which framing drives installs
Apple Search Ads — exact match only: offline poker, single player poker, poker vs ai, texas holdem offline, western / saloon poker; iPad placements included	250	CPI < \$1.50 and D1 > 35%, else pause keyword
Reddit promoted posts — r/poker + mobile-gaming subs; western-gaming interest targeting, trademark never in our copy; destination = web demo	150	Median demo session > 2 min; demo → store CTR > 8%
Reserve — weeks 3–4, doubles down on the cheapest <i>retained</i> install	150	—
Trailer & assets — one 45s character-led trailer, reused everywhere	100	Exists before any spend

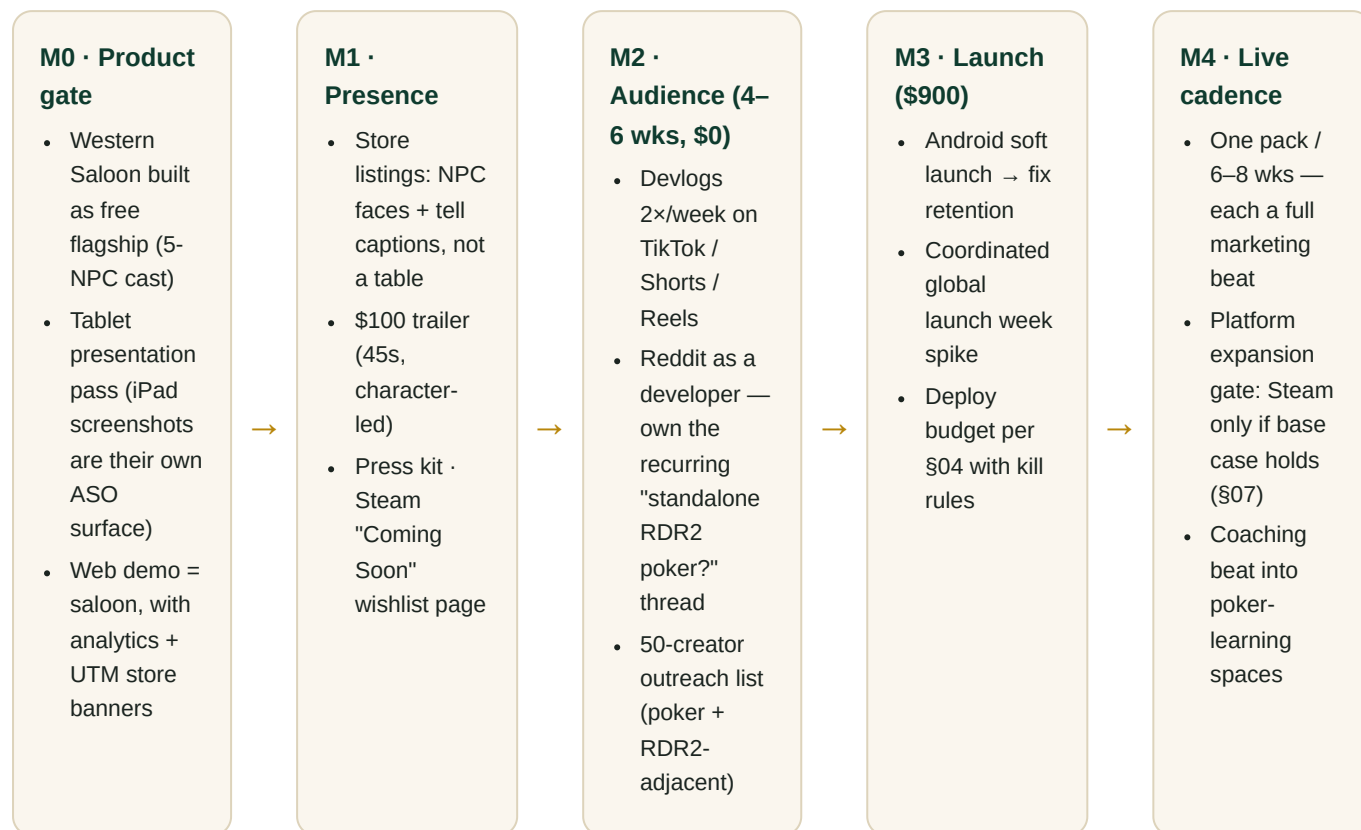


Deliberately \$0: Facebook/Google broad UA (viable minimums are 10–50× this budget), press agencies, paid reviews, feature brokers.

Free actions worth more than any paid line: twice-weekly devlogs, Reddit participation as a developer, press kit, pitching "best offline games" listicle authors, Steam wishlist page.

Global kill rule: any paid channel that cannot beat \$1.50 CPI with D7 > 10% after \$100 spent is stopped.

Roadmap — M0 to M4



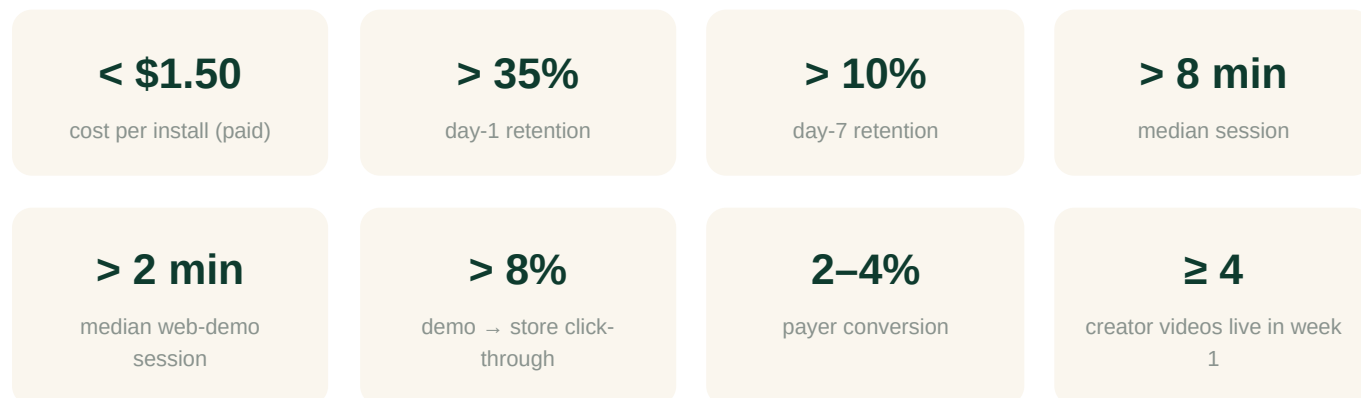
Gate A (blocks all spend): 3+ external testers each play the saloon 15–30 minutes unprompted **and can name the NPCs' personalities afterwards.**

Gate B (blocks global launch): soft-launch metrics — D1 > 35%, D7 > 10%, median session > 8 minutes.

The strategic A/B every launch asset answers

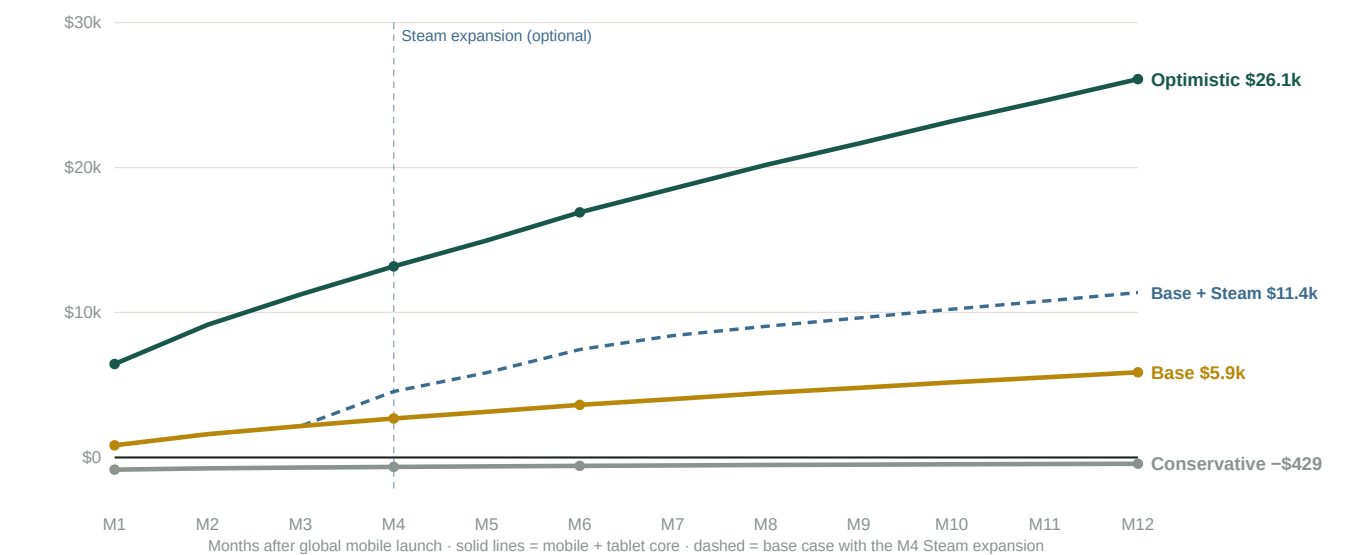
Does the **saloon-fantasy** framing or the **anti-chip-casino** framing acquire better-retaining players? Creator briefs and ad sets are split between the two; the winner leads every M4 beat.

Launch-week KPI targets



Projected profit over 12 months — mobile + tablet core

Cumulative profit = mobile/tablet IAP net (85% after store small-business cut) – \$1,150 upfront (ads, dev accounts) – \$50/month running costs. The dashed line overlays the optional M4 Steam expansion on the base case for comparison (70% net, –\$100 Steam Direct fee).

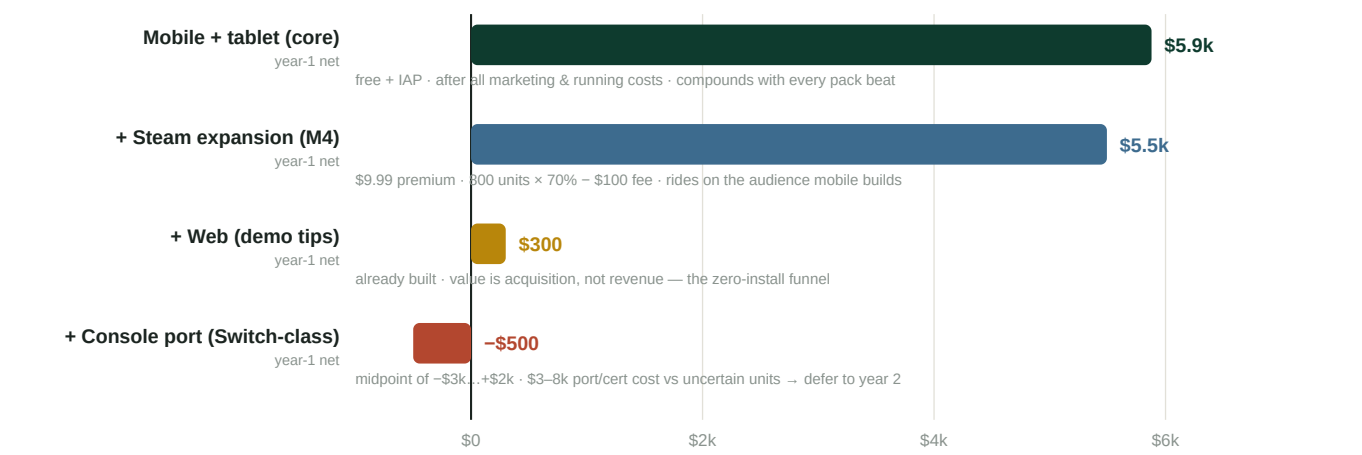


SCENARIO	INSTALLS (YR 1)	PAYER % · ARPPU	CORE PROFIT (M12)	BREAKEVEN	+ STEAM INCR.	WITH STEAM (M12)
Conservative Launch lands quietly; no creator video takes off; organic floor only.	11,100	2% · \$7	-\$429	—	\$1.6k	\$1.2k
Base Creator seeding produces a handful of mid-size videos; ASO cluster ranks; pack beats sustain a floor.	37,400	3% · \$8	\$5.9k	M1	\$5.5k	\$11.4k
Optimistic One creator video breaks out; the RDR2-itch framing spreads; Everything Edition attach rises.	91,000	4% · \$9	\$26.1k	M1	\$13.9k	\$40k

*Honest read: the conservative case ends ~\$430 under water on mobile alone and only turns positive with the Steam expansion — while the base case breaks even in month one. Total capital at risk is tiny either way; the budget's job is to find **one repeatable channel** (CPI < \$1.50, D7 > 10%), because that evidence — not launch revenue — is what justifies real spend afterwards.*

Platform profit comparison — why mobile + tablet is the core

Incremental year-1 net profit by platform, base-case scenario. Each expansion must beat the core on profit per unit of focus it consumes.

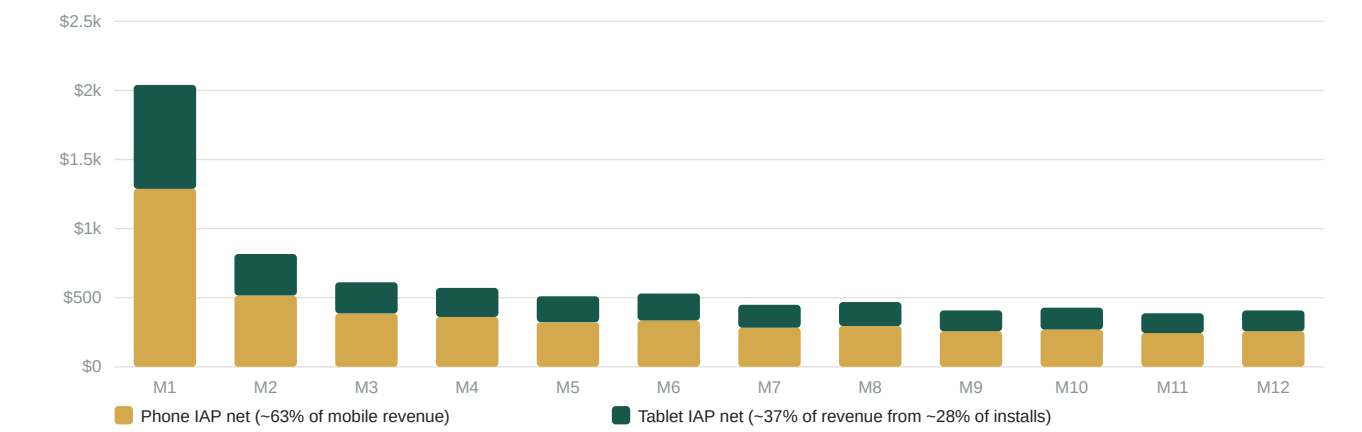


PLATFORM	BUILD COST TO REACH IT	ROLE
iOS / iPadOS / Android (free + IAP)	\$0 — already the product (store accounts ~\$124)	Core focus. Compounding: every pack beat re-monetises the whole installed base; tablets are the premium slice (~37% of revenue)
PC / Steam (\$9.99 premium)	Low — same Unity project, desktop target; \$100 Steam Direct + QA time	Expand at M4, gated on the mobile base case holding. Caution: its unit estimate rides on the audience the mobile launch builds, and it is front-loaded where mobile compounds
Web (Blazor demo)	\$0 — already built and auto-deployed	Funnel, not product. Zero-install trial that converts sceptics into store installs; tips at most as direct revenue
Console (Switch-class)	\$3k–8k — porting, devkit process, certification, ratings	Defer to year 2. Couch card-game fit is real, but certification overhead eats year-1 economics; revisit with mobile/Steam sales evidence

Reading: Steam is the only expansion that pays for itself in year 1 — and only after the mobile launch has built the audience its estimate depends on. Hence the sequencing: mobile/tablet first, Steam at M4 gated on data, web stays the funnel, console waits.

Base-case monthly net revenue — phone vs tablet

Launch spike decays to an ASO + devlog floor sustained by pack beats every 6–8 weeks. Tablets: ~28% of installs converting at ~1.5× phone rate → ~37% of revenue — the big-screen presentation pass pays for itself.



Risk register

RISK	MITIGATION
Fun bar not met	Gate A blocks all marketing spend until the saloon slice passes the 15–30 minute test with nameable NPC personalities
IP exposure	No third-party names or assets anywhere we control; comparisons live only in editorial / creator / community speech; repo name stays private
Poker flagged as gambling by ad platforms	Creatives lead with "no real money, no chips for sale"; simulated-gambling store questionnaires completed correctly from day one
Expectation gap vs AAA	Honest build-in-public devlogs; sell ambience and characters, never graphics parity
Web-demo cannibalisation	Acceptable — it converts sceptics; keep one pack store-exclusive if the data shows a problem

Measurement

UTM-tag every link; two funnels (web demo → store, store direct). Weekly dashboard: installs by source and device class (phone/tablet), CPI, D1/D7, median session, % reaching hand 10, payer conversion, pack attach rate, Everything-Edition take rate, Steam wishlists. The strategic A/B — saloon fantasy vs anti-chip-casino — is settled with launch-week data and leads all future beats.